

TAMBARAM

Chromepet » Pallavaram » Tambaram West » Rajakilpakkam » Mannivakkam » Guindy » Keelkattalai » Nanganallur » Guduvanchery » Hasthinapuram » Pammal » Tambaram East

Medavakkam » Srinivasa Nagar » Kathipara Junction » Kovilambakkam » Sadasivam Nagar » Potheri » Selaiyur » Sembakkam » St.Thomas Mount » Madipakkam » Urappakkam » Paranur

A new hangout in Chromepet

Once a site for dumping construction debris, this rectangular space below the Madras Institute of Technology flyover welcomes visitors with a host of features

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

It is 4.30 p.m. and school children and college students are enjoying the recreational facilities at the new park constructed below an arm of Madras Institute of Technology flyover, along Chitlapakkam Main Road, in Chromepet.

This rectangular space, known as MIT Park, is the latest attraction in the locality ever since it was opened on February 18.

From outside, one is drawn to the place seeing the pillars adorned with colourful murals, paintings of Bharatanatyam dancers, and wooden and stainless steel benches to sit. Inside, the amphitheatre invites visitors to host music and cultural programmes or a book-reading session. Next to it is a row of wooden dining seats. Names of social media apps such as Instagram, WhatsApp and Telegram seem to be an attempt to draw the attention of Gen



Z. There are also paintings and pictures of Indian hockey players (men and women).

With CCTV cameras, the park also promises safety.

The transformation of this place below the flyover is huge, considering that until last year it was used to dump construction debris.

"The area was an eyesore with trash and construction debris strewn around. Today, the park is a nice and cool place to hang out with friends," says H. Keerthi Hari Srinivasan.

J. Ragini Jayakumar, who came with her husband and two children, finds it a perfect space to unwind in the evening, especially after sunset.

There are many other things that should draw one to this place.

After the sunset, the gleaming lights add to the park's glitz, creating a vibrant atmosphere.

Make sure to test your vocabulary at the word game activity, which is a big draw among students. This requires one to form 15-letter words. The pebble path, gym and the play area for children are among other highlights.

K. Madhu Mitran and N. Dinesh Kumar, who are the trainers at the gym, say that the gym is equipped with all the standard gym equipment.

They will be helping bodybuilders and fitness enthusiasts who are required to carry their own to-



wels for the workout.

The park has received a thumbs-up from residents, and they want it

The dining area at MIT Park, pillars adorned with murals, and (below) the word game activity.

PHOTOS : SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

kept open throughout the day.

G. Sunaina, who brought her daughter to play, says, "At least in the weekends, the park could be kept open through the day."

The park is open from 5.30 a.m. to 9 a.m. and 4 p.m. to 8.30 p.m.

S. Balachander, Commissioner of Tambaram City Municipal Corporation, says, "We obtained prior permission from the State Highways Department before beginning the work to create a park, raised at a cost of ₹ 85 lakhs."

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Images include bovine presence on median at Melakottaiyur; the signal near Crescent College in Vandalur; Kolapakkam junction; and a view of the New Vandalur Flyover. PHOTOS: PRINCE FREDERICK

Lack of lighting, except for a scatter of a pathetically few high-mast lamps, and a ridiculously low median make Vandalur-Kelambakkam Road one of the deadliest thoroughfares in Chennai



Motorists drive '*blindfolded*' on major corridor

PRINCE FREDERICK

Manga legend Naruto Uzumaki's heroics include his adroit dodging of antagonist Madara's Light Fang. Imagine a parallel universe called Vandalur-Kelambakkam Road directing its Dark Fang at Naruto: this weapon is the exact opposite of Madara's, pitch darkness replacing blinding light, but it is just as deadly, if not more. How Naruto would fare on this "pitch-dark" road is probably open to debate, that is, among non-fans. But no discussion is warranted where regular motorists are concerned; they are bound to struggle navigating the road at night.

Expect a pat and damning word about the road's lighting quotient from the traffic police personnel attached to the Kilambakkam station that man the junction of GST Road and Vandalur-Kelambakkam Road,



going by what this writer heard from one of them recently: "No lights for twenty kilometres!" For factual accuracy, around 23 kilometres. That statement ignores the fact that high-mast lamps have been planted in the median at certain key junctions (examples include Kolapakkam and Kandigai) and around educational institu-

tions (examples include Tagore Engineering College, Sri Balaji Polytechnic College, Ramanujar Engineering College and Sri Balaji Arts and Science College). But these high-mast lights (some not so high) are few in number, some are only partly functional; and collectively, they cannot undo that damning remark. For all practical

purposes, it is a road plunged in darkness.

Median compounds matters

What gives the poor lighting on the road its barbed-wire deadliness is a structural design element on the ground: the low median. The median (maintained well by VIT) is so low that even a gnat can put all its six legs on it in one gentle heave, its wings kept folded in a resting state. Do not parse that idea; that is hyperbole, but you get the point. Except for a 400-metre stretch in Vengambakkam where a high median exists, Vandalur-Kelambakkam Road has a dangerously low median that leaks bipeds (human bipeds) quadrupeds (stray cattle), often taking motorists by round-eyed surprise. Dedicated road-crossings become a joke when every point of the median can be forded with the least of efforts.

Another deadly dimension: motorists on this road seem to be in the kind of hurry one witnesses in

a run chase in a high-scoring T20 match. In front of B.S. Abdur Rahman Crescent Institute of Science and Technology in Vandalur, a signal is operated, the support staff at the college operating the "levers" around an hour in the morning when students walk in, and for a similar duration in the evening when the students walk out. The ground staff points out despite the signals, they have to wait outside and put out their hands to stop motorists for the students to cross the road.

Dawn presages the day

As if to presage the poor lighting on Vandalur-Kelambakkam Road, a majority of the lamps on what is called the New Vandalur Bridge arching over the section of GST Road that nuzzles against Vandalur-Kelambakkam Road shirk work. And hard by, at the toe of Vandalur-Kelambakkam Road, a high-mast lamp functions with a skeletal staff, barring two, the lights are on indefinite medical leave.



An unsafe street in Nanmangalam

BALAMURUGAN MURTHY

Two months ago, Seventh Street in Perumal Nagar, Nanmanagalam, was irresponsibly filled with construction debris rather than being properly laid.

The debris includes broken concrete pieces, sharp stones and exposed steel rod projections.

Residents are having difficulty walking safely. Two-wheeler riders must navigate through sharp debris that could puncture their vehicles, or cause them to skid. An accident is only a matter of time.

The roads are intended to provide safe transport and not to become an obstacle course filled with hazardous waste.

Despite repeated complaints, no corrective action has been taken so far.

Balamurugan Murthy is a resident of Nanmangalam



Construction debris on Perumal Nagar Seventh Street in Nanmangalam. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Reclaim the pavement on Agaram Then Road

A. V. NARAYANAN

The pavements along the 200-Foot Agaram Then Road are a disgrace. Pedestrians are at risk while walking past parked autos, two-wheelers, and carrier vans. During evenings, eateries occupy key points on the carriageway. Motorcyclists ride freely on the pavement, forcing pedestrians onto the carriage-way. In some places, the pavement are not continuous, leaving a large gap. I request that the State Highways Department inspect these spots, fill the gaps, and remove the encroachments.

A. V. Narayanan is a resident of Thiruvanchery



Introduce trains from Tambaram

L. SUNDARARAMAN

The Southern Railway should operate Amrit Bharat and Vande Bharat trains to Coimbatore and Bengaluru, starting from Tambaram.

Currently, many passengers from Tambaram (East and West) and surrounding regions go to Chennai Central to board trains to these cities.

Also, the railway should restore the senior citizen concession on train fares, which was stopped during the pandemic.

L. Sundararaman is a resident of Chitlapakkam

Treated water should not be let into Thiruneermalai Periya Eri

B. SARAVANAN

Recently, the Commissioner of the Tambaram City Municipal Corporation stated that the sewage entering the Veeragharavan Eri in Chromepet - Tambaram Sanatorium regions would be diverted through peripheral drains into a sewage treatment plant. After treatment, the treated wa-

ter will be let into Thiruneermalai Periya Eri.

Water from a sewage treatment plant should not be let into the lake. The water bodies should receive fresh water.

This should not be allowed as it will contaminate the lake and groundwater, and the restoration work currently underway will be of no use.

B. Saravanan is a resident of Thiruneermalai



Sewage discharged into Thiruneermalai Lake. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Kudos to Highways

R V BASKARAN

Zebra crossing lines have been painted at the Camp Road junction. Photo: Special Arrangement

The State Highways Department has carried out a long-pending work on a section of Velachery Main Road, between Tambaram (East) railway station and Medavakkam junction.

The road margins have been painted along the entire stretch, and zebra crossings are marked at the traffic signals dotting the median area.

R V Baskaran is a resident of Selaipur



Carriageway sought between the tracks

N. RAMYA

The Chennai Division of the Southern Railway should construct a carriageway between the tracks, on the lines of one at the end of platforms 1A to 10 along Mathew Colony, a railway residential quarters along Velachery Main Road, Tambaram (East).

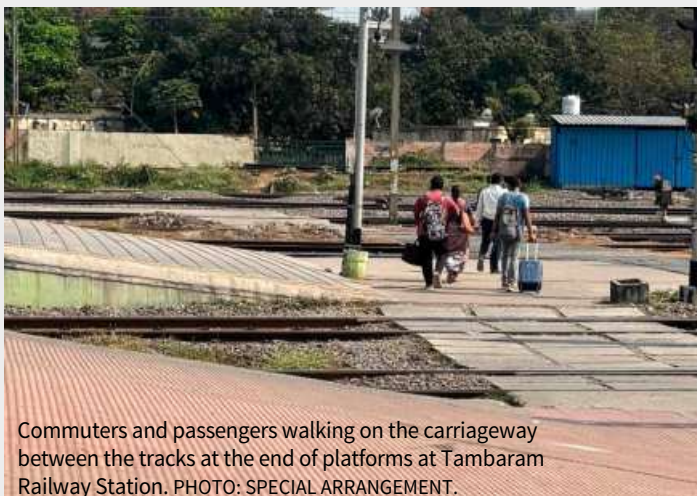
The Chennai Division has constructed a footbridge along Bharatha Matha Street and GST Road, Tambaram (East and West).

Work on providing either a lift or an escalator is underway on

platforms 1 to 8. When lifts or escalators go out of order, commuters and passengers have to climb a flight of steps. Providing the carriageway between the tracks and deploying staff to help the commuters and passengers reach and exit from the platforms will be very helpful.

Commuters and passengers from Tambaram (West) walk on the carriageway to board the trains at the platforms. Similarly, when exiting the railway station premises.

N. Ramya is a resident of Tambaram (East)



Commuters and passengers walking on the carriageway between the tracks at the end of platforms at Tambaram Railway Station. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT.

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'Heavy vehicles should not ply during peak hours'

Following a fatal accident on Nookampalayam Main Road recently, Federation of Perumbakkam Residents' Welfare Associations has submitted a list of necessary safety measures to the police



Representational picture.
PHOTO: R. RAVINDRAN

vehicle on Nookampalayam Main Road. The woman and her daughter were on the way to school.

K. Sarangadass, the federation secretary, says, "Heavy vehicles must be prevented from plying on Nookampalayam Road in Perumbakkam during rush hour. There must be a ban between 7 and 9 a.m. and from 3 p.m. to 5 p.m."

Police personnel should be deployed to curb speeding; and parking of vehicles along the road should be prohibited.

The width of the road should be increased to 60 feet, medians should be installed, and all encroachments should be removed to ensure a safe commute, say residents.

Text: T.S. Atul Swaminathan

The Federation of Perumbakkam Residents' Welfare Associations has submitted a petition to the Inspector of Police, Traffic, Medavakkam, Tambaram

City Police Commissionerate outlining measures to prevent accidents.

Recently, a woman and her daughter were run over by a heavy

Meeting to protest STP at Madambakkam lake today



Madambakkam Lake.

A 'thousand people protest meeting' by the Madambakkam residents will be held on March 15, near Anna Nagar haltover in Madambakkam, from 10 a.m. to 1 p.m., to oppose the plan by the Tambaram City Municipal Corporation to construct a 300 MLD (Million Litres a Day) capacity sewage treatment plant in the vicinity of Madambakkam Lake.

Brigadier Mohan Thomas, a social activist, says, "The litres of sewage brought here will turn the lake into a cesspool, and the groundwater will be poisoned, rendering it unfit for consumption."

Residents and the Indian Air Force Station depend on groundwater fed by the lake. We have no other water source, say, residents.

Bottlenecks persist on Radha Nagar Main Road despite new subway

Illegal parking, encroachments and lack of traffic regulation slow movement at key junctions; police say action will be taken and patrol stepped up

T. ARVIND

It has been nearly two months since the inauguration of the Radha Nagar subway in Chromepet, which finally replaced Level Crossing 27 after nearly two decades of demand and eliminated long waits for motorists. The subway, which runs along Radha Nagar Main Road for more than 2 km, serves as a crucial link connecting GST Road with localities such as Nemilichery, Nanmangalam and Kurinji Nagar.

Soon after its launch in January, *The Hindu's* Downtown had reported that the facility largely improved traffic flow for motorists, barring a few minor issues.



However, two months on, commuters say traffic bottlenecks have surfaced at a few points along Radha Nagar Main Road. While the flow of vehicles from GST Road through the subway remains smooth up to the stretch near Canara Bank, congestion begins soon after that at certain locations.

Encroachments narrow stretch
Motorists say the first bottleneck

occurs soon after the Rajaji Road junction, where illegal parking and encroachments in front of eateries slow down traffic.

The situation is particularly noticeable near the Bharathi Street junction. Vehicles parked along the roadside and customers standing outside bakeries and eateries reduce the already narrow carriageway. In some cases, customers consuming food on the roadside further shrink the availa-

ble road space, forcing motorists to navigate through a constricted stretch.

PHOTOS: T. ARVIND

Chaos at busy junction

About 100 metres further, the junction of Hanuman Koil Street and Naidu Shop Road witnesses heavy congestion, especially during the evening hours. Commuters travelling from Pallavaram on the northern side and Hasthinapuram on the southern side converge at this junction before dis-

persing to different neighbourhoods.

With little or no traffic police presence at the junction, motorists say the stretch often turns chaotic during peak hours.

"I have been running my flower stall here for 20 years. Business has become dull, particularly after the new subway opened," said Jothilakshmi, a vendor at the junction. "Continuous honking and traffic congestion make it difficult for customers to even notice my stall," she added. Autorickshaw driver Kothandaraman said the traffic booth at the junction was rarely manned on a regular basis. "Police personnel usually come only during political events or special occasions," he said.

Commuters also pointed out that frequent loading and unloading of supplies by bakeries and other shops in the surrounding area during peak hours further aggravates congestion.

When contacted, Jean Benson, Assistant Commissioner of Police (Traffic), said personnel from the Armed Reserve were deployed to man the booth at the junction in the absence of regular traffic staff. He added that instructions had already been issued to take action against road encroachments along the stretch. "Suitable directions will be given to the Sub-Inspector concerned to ensure regular patrol and monitoring at the busy junctions," Mr. Benson said. Traders and commuters hope that the authorities will take steps to restore smooth traffic flow so that the full benefits of the subway commuting can be realised.

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

Anyone with normal vision would need just a quarter of a glance to distinguish a ₹50 note from a ₹500 note. For a visually impaired individual, any effort in that direction would require dependence on others. The Tamil Nadu state branch of National Association for the Blind (NAB) is seeking to cut out that dependence by distributing “Vision Wallets” to visually impaired individuals. On March 13, at its office in Kodungaiyur, it distributed these Vision Wallets to 15 visually impaired women, to mark International Women’s Day. The 15 are part of a batch of 250 visually impaired individuals across Tamil Nadu to receive this assistive device. The Vision Wallets are sponsored by Synamedia India Pvt. Ltd., Tharamani; Reachem Laboratory Chemicals Pvt. Ltd.; and the Rotaract Clubs. Applications would open after this batch of 250 are served.

What is a Vision Wallet anyway? Developed by H Vision India Pvt. Ltd., the device allows users to instantly identify currency denominations and detect counterfeit notes without relying on a smartphone or internet connectivity. It resembles a conventional men’s wallet fitted with a compact electronic module. Embedded sensors detect the currency note and relay the denomination through audio output in Hindi and English. Specially designed grooves guide the note into position from any corner, enabling the sensors to read it accurately and announce the value almost instantly without internet connectivity. The device came to NAB’s attention after one of the organisation’s secretaries encountered it at an assistive technology exhibition organised by Vellore Institute of Technology. Dipti Bhatia, CEO of NAB’s Tamil Nadu branch, says it was obvious to them that it offered a practical solution. “Many people think visually impaired persons can simply use smartphones or Google Pay,” she observes. “But not everyone owns a smartphone or is comfortable using one. Even existing apps require scanning and waiting, and sometimes the voice output is too soft or the scan fails. The wallet offers a simple and quick hands-on solution.”

The priority list

The organisation received more than 250 applications from across the State. However, limited funding meant only a small number of wallets could be distributed in the first phase. Beneficiaries were selected based on income: those earning less than ₹2 lakh annually received the device free of cost;



A wallet with ‘eyes’

National Association for the Blind — Tamil Nadu has launched an initiative to distribute Vision Wallets to visually impaired individuals with an event organised at its office in Chennai on March 13. The assistive device spells out the denomination of a currency note



Snapshots of the event at NAB’s Chennai office; and the Vision Wallet. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A word from the beneficiaries

Mary from Pallikaranai earns her livelihood through chair re-caning. Running a business is tough, doing so as a visually challenged person, tougher still. The initiative by the Tamil Nadu branch of the National Association for the Blind (NAB), has taken one worry off her table. “Now I can confidently say that I am

giving the correct amount without worrying about being cheated,” says Mary.

Another beneficiary, Krithika, a first-year student of Madras Christian College, says this Vision Wallet would put an end to a dependence while shopping: “asking the person next to me about the denomination of the currency I was giving”.

those earning between ₹2 lakh and ₹5 lakh paid a nominal contribution of ₹500; and those earning above ₹5 lakh are expected to purchase it independently. The device carries an approximate market price of ₹3,600. Priority was also given to students and individuals who frequently handle cash such as street vendors, small traders and others whose livelihoods depend on regular cash transactions.

The initiative was spearheaded by Vikas, honorary secretary of the NAB Tamil Nadu branch. After testing it, he recognised its practicality immediately. “When I placed currency notes on the device, I found it to be very useful and practical,” he said. The initiative also hit an early setback when an NGO that had initially planned to supply the wallets withdrew from the programme, by which point hundreds had already applied. “We felt we could not abandon them because the wallet could significantly improve their independence,” said Vikas. The organisation turned to donors and supporters to sustain the project.

The origin story

The Vision Wallet itself originated from a moment of observation. In 2019, while pursuing product design, founder of H Vision India Pvt. Ltd., Hasin Vaidya visited the Blind People’s Association in Ahmedabad and noticed a visually impaired man struggling to identify a ₹10 note after buying tea. “To make a payment of ten rupees, the person took around four to five minutes,” he recalled. “Even after giving the note, he asked the tea seller to confirm if it was a ₹10 note.” That moment led Hasin to rethink the wallet entirely. “I thought of making the wallet itself smart,” he said. “In the same wallet where they keep their currency notes and documents, they should also be able to identify the notes.” User feedback shaped several improvements. Battery life extended from 1.5 days to two days to nearly a month, with only an hour of charging required. The automatic power feature was replaced with a manual on-off switch, allowing users to activate the device only when needed. Some users asked for coin identification but it was not implemented because it was technically impractical. After years of development, the company launched its first production batch in 2024 and began collaborating with NGOs across India. Users who can afford the device can buy it directly online from the manufacturer, at hvision.in. NAB welcomes donors to support their initiative to distribute the device to visually impaired individuals. Donors can sponsor the cost of three or five wallets. NAB can be contacted at 9840917314.

Young voices for organ donation

Through 'Angels of Change', Chennai-based Mohan Foundation is raising youngsters to serve as advocates for organ donation



LIFFY THOMAS

When a biology lesson on organ systems generated immense interest among Class VIII students of The Pupil International School, the biology teacher Mathura saw an opportunity for an extended class, one about organ donation helmed by subject matter experts from Mohan Foundation. The session eventually led to the formation of Organ Donation Awareness Club led by 25 Class VIII students.

In February, the Club conducted an awareness campaign at the school with a skit and a song, thoughtfully executed by the students to engage their peers. A short film *Second Beat* with students, parents and teachers as actors sends out a powerful message on grief, hope and courage inherent in the process of organ donation.

As an extension of Club's activities, students are reaching out to the communities around them. In a rangoli competition at her gated community in Iyyappanthangal, Aadhira K. drew a design to draw residents' attention to organ donation. Her classmates Deepthi T. has met 15 residents at her gated community in Porur to throw light on organ donation. And Shivam S. along with a group is getting a skit on the topic ready to present it at a city college.

Mohan Foundation, a Chennai-based non-profit promoting organ donation, transplantation and public awareness started 'Angels of Change' before the pandemic to encourage young voices to become advocates for the cause. Over the last two years, this programme has been customised for school students, and it travels across the country.

Before the pandemic, students of Punjab Association Group of Schools in Chennai signed up for the 'Angels of Change' programme. Two schools from Delhi have initiated this programme for their highschoolers. Likewise, Mumbai also has schools that are showing interest in running this programme as a club activity.

Hemal Kanvinde, Quality Assurance Officer, Mohan Foundation, says some students sign up as individuals, either taking it up during their summer or winter break or as an internship.

A student volunteer from Dubai (now pursuing her MBBS), who completed the programme, went on to receive The Diana Award.

"The motivation to sign up for this programme is different, some are drawn by an incident in the family, some to engage in a meaningful act of service as part of their curriculum and many out of curiosity," says Hemal.

"We support them 2-3 times before we let them do activities on their own," says Hemal, inviting more schools to be part of the



Aadhira K from Iyyappanthangal drew this rangoli at a competition in her gated community to raise awareness about organ donation; and (above) the batch performs a skit.

programme.

The Foundation also runs an Ambassador programme, which is open to students and adults.

Legacy club

The Foundation is also working on putting Angels of Change as a

legacy club in school, so that the initiative gets passed on from one batch to another.

Dr. Saveetha, director, The Pupil International School, says the idea to start an organ donation awareness club came from the students and we want them to

The programme

The Angels of Change programme has three modules. The first one is an online programme, which essentially functions as a primer on organ donation. The three-to-four-hour course also covers FAQs that children can prepare themselves for while talking to others.

The second part is conducted in person and involves meeting a recipient, donor and talking to experts, an example being a grief counsellor. The last part deals with ways to engage in positive conversations and the right vocabulary that must be used. For example, saying "organs were harvested" is not saying it in an acceptable manner.

Following the completion of the course, participants get a kit comprising IEC materials, donor card and flyer. The participants are expected to conduct two public awareness talks or campaigns such as a poster competition, debate, awareness talk in their parents circle, done under the guidance of Mohan Foundation staff as part of the completion of the training.

For details, write to info@mohanfoundation.org

handhold their juniors to carry forward the activities they began. We are working out a plan to see how the regular activities can be conducted from the coming academic year.

Recognising the *Unrecognised*

The third edition of Rotary Club of Madras Metro's Spirit of India Awards honoured four individuals from four cities



The awardees seen with Veeraraghav, Executive Editor, NDTV (3rd from left); Dr. Vijaya Bharathi Rangarajan (3rd from right); Club President Mahesh Krishna (2nd from right); Club Secretary Binny Rajkumar (extreme right); Suresh Jain (2nd from left) and Ram Kumar P T (extreme left)

The Rotary Club of Madras Metro presented the 3rd Edition of the Spirit of India Awards 2026, a pan-India initiative dedicated to "Recognising the Unrecognised" – individuals who have made extraordinary contributions to the society, often away from the public spotlight, on March 13 at Madras Management Association.

The event was graced by T. M. Veeraraghav, Executive Editor, NDTV, as the chief guest, and Rtn Dr. Vijaya Bharathi Rangarajan, District Governor Elect, 2027 - 28 as the guest of honour.

The winners are: Chandana Sinha, Inspector, RPF (Guardian of Hope), Lucknow, for her exem-

plary service in protecting vulnerable children and ensuring safety and dignity within the railway ecosystem; Jagriti Mishra, animal activist from Delhi, recognised for her relentless dedication to animal welfare and advocacy for the protection and humane treatment of animals; P. Naveen Kumar, Champion of Dignity from Erode, was acknowledged for his inspiring work in empowering communities and upholding human dignity through social initiatives; and Dr. Suneela Kumar Hebhi - Healing Beyond Boundaries, Bengaluru, for his compassionate medical service and commitment to providing healthcare that reaches

beyond conventional limits.

The Spirit of India Awards initiative by the Rotary Club of Madras Metro aims to spotlight unsung heroes across India whose courage, compassion, and commitment make a meaningful difference in society, said a release.

Through this platform, the club continues its mission of promoting humanitarian values and encouraging individuals who work tirelessly for the welfare of others without seeking recognition.

The president of the club A. S. Mahesh Krishna expressed that these awards serve as a reminder that true heroes often work silently, driven only by the spirit of service and humanity.

'Super Chennai Manifesto 2026' unveiled

Consolidating recommendations from senior bureaucrats, urban planners, industry representatives, sustainability experts and cultural leaders during the Super Chennai Conclave, the manifesto will be formally presented to key policymakers

Super Chennai, a citizen-led city-wide branding movement, has unveiled the Super Chennai Manifesto 2026, a comprehensive civic blueprint titled "Super Chennai Compact: For a Global, Resilient City." The manifesto outlines a structured, data-backed roadmap to position Chennai among the world's most competitive, sustainable and culturally confident cities.

Evolving from a city-focused dialogue platform into a structured civic movement, Super Chennai has consolidated recommendations from senior bureaucrats, urban planners, industry representatives, sustainability experts and cultural leaders during the Super Chennai Conclave, along with inputs gathered through citizen outreach programmes. The manifesto will be formally presented to key policymakers and senior bureaucrats, with detailed recommendations submitted as part of a structured engagement process aimed at collaborative implementation, said a press release.

The highlights

* Launch fully functional and standardised corporation websites, pu-

blish ward-level performance dashboards ranking waste, roads, lights and grievance resolution.

* Adopt single integrated tenders for roads, drains and utilities to end repeated digging, reform FSI norms along transit corridors for vertical mixed-use growth.

* Integrate MTC buses with Metro, Suburban and MRTS networks, implement AI-enabled traffic optimisation, enforce disciplined bus bays and auto halting.

* Implement safe routes to school citywide, eliminate exposed mud shoulders, mandate universal accessibility standards in all public and commercial spaces, and enforce strict anti-encroachment and street discipline.

* Deploy AI-driven smart monsoon systems, publish a long-term State Water Security Strategy, expand reservoirs and desalination.* Mandate 70% green power for data centres, relocate high-load compute zones away from residential areas, anchor future industrial corridors in renewable energy, and enforce strong technical standards for large developments.

* Train thousands of taxi and auto drivers as city ambassadors.

ProNutramax introduces two brands

ProNutramax, a health drink company, has launched two brands: 'Pro Nutra Kidz' for the mind and body, and 'Authentic Natural Indian (ANI)', aimed at preserving traditional Indian cooking.

Pro Nutra Kidz comes in two flavours: classic vanilla and rich chocolate, designed to support strong bones, boost immunity and provide sustained energy.

ANI offers a variety of spices and instant mixes, including 'idli podi,' 'rasam,' 'sambar,' 'puliyocharai,' and 'rava idli' mixes.

Latha Dubay, founder of ProNutramax, in a release said, "Today's new-generation parents often find it hard to balance their kids' hectic school schedules with proper nutrition, while also trying to keep the authentic flavours of traditional home cooking.

Understanding this, ProNutramax has combined science-backed nutrition with the trusted taste of the past to bring back parent-approved nutrition to every family's table, said the release. For details, contact 95009 10040 98402 97720. Website : <https://pronutramax.com/>

Workshop on GST

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute, a Department of MSME - Tamil Nadu is conducting a workshop on "GST E-Way billing and income tax returns submission" from March 16 to 18 at its premises on EDII Office Road, Ekkattuthangal, SIDCO Industrial Estate Guindy.

Baking workshop

The institute is also conducting a baking workshop from March 24 to 27. The programme will focus on making baked products such as cookies, breads, cakes, and brownies from millets.

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Will sustainable cooking gain a toehold?

As shortage in supply of LPG affects commercial kitchens, an enterprise working in that space with units in R.A. Puram and Semmancherry and a business promoting sale of traditional cookware with outlets at ECR and R.A. Puram weigh in on this question

PRINCE FREDERICK

Solutions that are sustainable in the long run and dependable in all seasons but requiring modifications in processes and behaviours in the short term will be ignored as long as solutions, easier but unreliable in some situations and even harmful in some others, are readily on tap. When that free-flowing tap suddenly settles to a trickle, sustainable solutions might get a toehold.

Currently, sustainable cooking solutions are gaining a toehold in commercial kitchens. Between jittery fingers, they are twirling various options that can do without the LPG cylinder. Some of these kitchens might be taking time out, but backstage they could be exploring sustainable cooking options.

The Semmancherry unit of Dabbakaran recently put out a note for its “Dear Dabbakaran Family” that “due to the ongoing crisis in commercial LPG cylinder supply, we are unable to source new cylinders. We deeply regret to inform you that we will not be able to supply food from 12th March, 2026 until this issue is resolved.

We are looking out for other alternative options to resolve the issue. We assure you that we will resume our services as early as possible.”

What pops out at any reader of this communication (it should, if it does not) is “other al-



Wood-fired mud stove in a pastoral setting in India. Sleek and fancy wood-fired stoves are also being offered as an option in modern domestic kitchen systems. Will commercial kitchens now adopt this form of sustainability at scale? GETTY IMAGES

ternative options”.

When *The Hindu Downtown* got in touch with a team member of Dabbakaran, it is obvious that behind the temporarily lowered shutters of its Semmancherry unit, the business which caters meals for subscribers is not leaving any stone (actually, ‘any wood’ or ‘food waste’) unturned in cranking up the services quickly and preventing a stretched lull.

The team member observes they are considering the option of cooking with wood, minimal wood, on a blower-assisted stove.

The team member pulls out another option that is under study: zero-waste cooking. Turning food waste into gas, popularly known as biogas.

The Semmancherry unit caters for 500 members, many

of whom are in the sixty-plus age bracket, and depend heavily on this service (breakfast, lunch and dinner), hence the desperate attempts to kickstart it with alternative cooking methods, says the team member. Dabbakaran continues to run its kitchen in R.A. Puram with a trimmed-down menu; this kitchen serves around 900 meals (lunch and dinner) every day.

Traditional cookware in focus

Kayal Sriram runs an eponymous enterprise, Essential Traditions by Kayal, that sells traditional iron, cast-iron, soapstone and brass cookware and serveware from two physical outlets, one on ECR and the other at R.A. Puram, and online. Domestic kitchens have constituted the business's strong base; but the current crisis seems bent on extending the bu-

siness into the commercial kitchen, as the movement in that direction has already happened, precisely one month before this crisis showed up on the horizon.

Kayal notes the foray one month ago into serving commercial kitchens had to do with “serving”, that is sale of serveware. Now, following the events of the last few days, the focus has widened to include cookware.

Kayal points out that the efforts would be directed towards scaling traditional cookware, making them more capacious: large-sized cookware. Among the traditional cookware that are likely to gain traction after the recent turn of events, Kayal names wood-fired stoves, because they are already leaving their “flavour” behind in modern kitchens. She explains that modern kitchens are incorporating wood-fired stoves as an option.

She is also witnessing an interest in *kumuti adupu* (charcoal stoves) as a result of the LPG crisis. While she has no problem with these being used in domestic settings, she considers huge charcoal stoves infeasible, even inadvisable (given their capacity

for pollution when used at scale) in commercial kitchens. In certain parts of the country, particularly the NCR region, a ban on the use of these stoves in commercial kitchens are firmly in place.

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